joyousness on their part, because some of them had aspirations to have the job themselves.'

The early indications were that the satraps would not take Ratan seriously, much less countenance his leadership. They had hoped that he would not play an active role in the group and that they would continue to lead their companies as they did under JRD, with all the freedom and liberty to act virtually without interference. Under Ratan, they did not follow some of the traditions, nor did they abide by the rules. They did not, however, realize that Ratan is tenacious in any fight that he is compelled to wage, 'winning when he does fight', as *The Economist* says. It is not an isolated opinion. His fellow industrialist, Anand Mahindra, says, 'Ratan's aggression is understated.'

Preparing for the Future

After he became group chairman, Ratan focused his attention on reorganizing and restructuring it. This, however, flew in the face of the autonomy of the satraps who were only willing to countenance Ratan as a figurehead.

One of the significant steps that Ratan took was the reintroduction of a retirement age for directors on various company boards. When Ratan had taken over, the individuals 'could serve in Tata companies as chairmen till they wanted', Rajiv Dube, the former executive officer and general manager, Group Chairman's Office, Tata Industries, recounts. Key office holders continued to stay in office despite the inevitable vicissitudes of age they faced.

Dube recalls a 'funny saying' in Bombay House about not having a retirement age policy. Once a key functionary occupied an office in the iconic building, he remained there until his death. The next journey of such officials was said to be from 'Bombay House to Doongerwadi [a Parsi cemetery in Malabar Hill]'.

Ratan saw the absence of an effective retirement policy as a serious drawback in the Tata governance architecture. For instance, this blocked the career of young executives. Dube says that Ratan was keen to 'engage with the world' and it became incumbent upon him to evolve a retirement plan as a step among several others to make the Tatas 'more professional'. Dube